

Develop and Demonstrate Loyalty: Loyalty – A Family Model, Featuring Joan Cronan

Joan Cronan, Women's Athletic Director Emeritus, University of Tennessee

Pat's philosophy was ... "If you want to develop loyalty, the first thing you have to do is demonstrate it. My staff and my family are one and the same. My staff is my family."

What would it take to be considered one of the most loyal leaders in your company, where your team is always willing to go the extra mile for you and you are a leader the entire team looks to for guidance and direction?

What would that mean to you? Is that even possible?

Pat (Summitt) was fiercely loyal. Pat was also very clear about what loyalty was and what it wasn't. Loyalty was not a one-way street where people blindly followed others. It was very much a give-and-take where loyalty has to be given in order to be received.

Pat never wanted to be surrounded by "yes people" who appeared loyal and would never challenge her when needed or push her to get better. The best way to acknowledge talent is to let people do the job you hired them to do and trust them to do it.

This is often difficult for leaders – letting go and trusting.

Pat's humility allowed her to see that if she surrounded herself with "yes people" who simply pandered to her every decision, Tennessee basketball would not go very far.

She wanted coaches who she believed were better in areas which she knew were not her greatest strengths. She wanted coaches who would challenge her and call her out when they felt her actions or emotions were becoming counterproductive.

When she found those coaches, she created an environment where her coaches were free to tell her what she needed to hear, not just what she wanted to hear. She gave them both responsibility and authority and created loyalty by treating them with trust, gratitude, and ultimate respect.

Remember, you build loyalty first by being loyal. So write out a loyalty list today.

List three important people in your life and then define three ways you commit to demonstrate your loyalty to them.

Post this list on your mirror or another prominent place where you will see it each day and condition your focus on being loyal.